

Chapter 120-2

A long time passed—so long that Liang Shi's thoughts had begun to drift, staring blankly at a fixed point—before Chen Mian finally spoke, her voice obscure: "She is not her."

—She is not her.

The phone calls that could still be made—the person answering was not Qi Jiao.

The voice that could still be heard—that was also not Qi Jiao.

The similar face that could still be seen—that still was not Qi Jiao.

Chen Mian's voice seemed to come from the depths of the sea, carrying bone-piercing coldness and deep despair.

Hearing this, Liang Shi met her gaze. Those eyes hidden behind coldness became warm, the corners tinged with a trace of red.

After a moment, Chen Mian asked bluntly: "What do you want to ask?"

"How do you know the person now isn't her?" Liang Shi asked in a low voice.

Chen Mian licked her lips, slowly exhaled, and asked back very softly: "How could I not tell?"

"Have you ever loved someone?" Chen Mian continued to ask.

Liang Shi paused.

"She's dead." Chen Mian said. "No matter how similar that person is, she's just a substitute."

"It's easy to imitate the form, but hard to imitate the spirit. She is her—no one can imitate her." Chen Mian's voice was unusually certain, though one could faintly hear a trace of sorrow.

An artist's words were always somewhat obscure, requiring deeper excavation.

Liang Shi stared at her. "Do you know her true cause of death?"

"I don't know." Chen Mian said. "It should be related to her mother? I'm not sure."

Chen Mian shrugged. "You came to find me—I thought you knew."

Her mood sank again. Without her guard up, her surface indifference looked more like world-weariness.

A heavy sense of world-weariness was revealed through her eyes, through her every movement—exceptionally obvious.

Under that ink-blue hair was her concealed gland. Behind her ear at the gland location was a lily flower tattoo.

She subconsciously rubbed that tattoo, looking at Liang Shi with an indifferent smile. "I'm not anyone to her, so I can't do anything about it."

The implication being—I have no standing to investigate her cause of death, no standing to do anything.

Liang Shi asked again: "Then do you know why she jumped off the building?"

Chen Mian shook her head: "We never saw each other again after she jumped."

Chen Mian didn't know much. She knew very little about Qi Jiao's death.

It was Liang Shi who tactfully told her that her suspicions were correct.

Upon hearing this answer, Chen Mian's expression shifted slightly, seemingly mocking.

When Liang Shi asked her whether it was because of Qi Jiao that she had spoken to her in middle school, Chen Mian nodded.

Chen Mian said that back then, Qi Jiao often mentioned a little sister to her.

She also said she had once seen Qi Jiao watching her figure from the shadows.

Later, when they became close, Qi Jiao told Chen Mian: "She's my little sister."

When mentioning Liang Shi, Qi Jiao would rarely speak at length, her brows and eyes curving into a smile, saying how wonderful it was that she was doing well.

So Chen Mian would talk to her in the art studio, would readily agree to meet her after seeing her messages.

Would agree to requests that were somewhat unreasonable for Chen Mian.

To Chen Mian, Liang Shi was Qi Jiao's "keepsake."

"Did you ever try to stop her?" Liang Shi asked.

Hearing this, Chen Mian curved her lips into a mocking smile. "I told her we should live for each other."

Liang Shi: "...Then she..."

"She probably couldn't hold on anymore." Chen Mian gripped the warm glass, the water inside swaying. The veins on the back of her hand bulged. "She was already in so much pain—how could I selfishly ask her to live for me?"